

till you drop' and pop-culture figures like *Sex and the City*'s Carrie Bradshaw – who famously said, 'I like my money right where I can see it – hanging in my closet' – as the pin-up girl for conspicuous consumption, it's often treated as no more serious a problem than a runny nose.

Laving insists on using the phrase 'shopping addiction' as it shares many of the markers of other behavioural addictions, such as gambling. The issue is not only the money spent, but also the time and energy that addicts spend on their habits. Laving says:

Sometimes people will spend hours and hours browsing online, or doing what I call 'vicarious spending'; they will put things in a wish list or a basket, and have a clear preoccupation with the search that takes away from other areas of your life and self-development. [A shopping addiction] is continuing to overspend despite the negative consequences such as mounting debt, fractures in your close relationships, internally feeling very stressed and anxious and ashamed of what you are doing, and juggling [money] between accounts.

These are all of the markers I experienced at my worst; you might be experiencing one or two, even if you are mostly sensible with money.

Most people occasionally splurge but can pull them selves back, Laving says. Others might overspend at times and find themselves short on cash to pay utilities, and do not have a savings plan, but will have periods where their finances are healthy. Do you identify as either of these types of spender? Saving for a deposit requests not just a pull back, but a full-blown retreat – perhaps for several years – from shopping centres and e-stores.

Overspending and shopping serve a purpose, Laving says, that often has little to do with the purchases themselves. Frequently, chronic spenders also lack financial literacy, for the simple reason they choose not to learn.

'Know about the basics of credit cards and interest rates,' Laving says.

'Making a table of all of your expenditure in categories can sometimes be the pivotal moment [for changing habits] because it is the stark reality of where the spending is going, and the imbalance.' When credit card details are instantly saved by e-boutiques for the next time you return, the transaction can happen with such ease, like a reflex, that it seems intangible,